A FREE DM PROCEDURE · LONG ISLAND DUNGEON MASTER

The Door Is Locked and the Key Is Gone

A free procedure for the moment the party cannot get through and the rogue failed the roll. Five questions, asked in order, each with a ruling attached.

Five questions · the rulings on the kit · one d12 · fifth edition (SRD 5.1)

A free procedure for the moment the party cannot get through and the rogue failed the roll. Five questions, asked in order, each with a ruling attached.

The rogue rolls a 7 against the lock. You say the lock holds. The rogue asks to try again. Four people look at you.

What happens next at most tables is one of two things. The rogue rolls until the number comes up, and the lock was never a lock. Or you say no, the fighter says "I kick it in," you set a number from nowhere, and the room beyond, which you had not thought about, is now the room where the fight is.

Neither of those is a ruling. The five questions below are. You answer each one out loud in a sentence, and each answer moves the scene.

Nothing here needs a stat block. It runs in fifth edition and in anything older.

The five questions

1. Is this door doing a job?

A door is locked because somebody wanted something kept in or kept out. If you cannot say what, in four words, the door is not doing a job and the failed roll was a stiff lock. The pick catches on the second pull. Say so and move on; the minute it cost is the whole price.

A locked door with nothing behind it that anyone cares about is a delay with a hit point total. Do not run it.

If you can say what the door is for, keep going. The next four questions are for that door.

2. What did the failed roll already cost?

The die is spent. A failure bought something. Name it before anybody speaks again.

A minute. The pick was in the lock a long time. This matters only if something is moving in the place. If nothing is, say so, and the lock opens in ten more minutes without a roll.

A pick. It snapped. The kit has more; one is gone. If it was the last, the kit is done until a town.

The lock. The broken tine is in the keyway. Nothing opens this door from either side now but force, and the key no longer works for whoever holds it.

A sound. A pick working is quiet. A pick snapping, a boot against the base of the door, the rogue swearing: those carry.

Pick the one that fits the place and say it. "Can I try again" is answered by that cost, so name the cost first.

The retry rule, since it comes up: the same hands do not roll twice at the same lock. One roll was the attempt. A second character holding the tools gets one roll, and that is all the tools get at this door tonight. Without proficiency the tools are a bent wire: the check is made without the bonus.

3. Who else knows this door is locked?

Whoever locked it. That person has a key, and the key is somewhere in the world the party is standing in: on a belt, on a nail by the kitchen door, in the pocket of the body in the corridor behind them, round the neck of the sleeper in the next room. Know where it is before anyone asks. A key that exists somewhere gives the scene a direction the lock did not.

Two things the pick already told the rogue, free, with no roll. If the lock turned and the door still did not give, it is barred from the far side, and a bar on the far side was put there by someone on the far side. Either they are still in there, or that room has another way out and they used it. If the lock did not turn at all, it is a lock, there is a key, and the key is not in the room beyond.

4. What does forcing it buy, and what does it spend?

Force works. A wooden door is wood. What you decide now, and say before the first swing, is how long it takes and how loud it is. The next section is every tool the party reaches for, with the ruling on each.

Force always spends two things: time, and the answer to the last question. Everything in earshot now knows where the party is and that the party is coming in slowly.

5. WHAT IS ON THE OTHER SIDE RIGHT NOW?

The failed roll gave the far side a minute. Decide what it did with that minute before you answer the next "I try."

Nothing. It is a storeroom. Say so.

Something woke.

Something moved toward the sound, and is standing on the far side of the door with a hand on the bolt, listening the way the rogue is listening.

Something moved away from the sound, and the room beyond is empty of the thing the party came for.

Something sent for help, and help is coming by the other door.

The door opens, when it opens, onto a room that has changed. A failed roll that changes the room beyond was worth rolling.

What the Party Reaches For Next

The standard kit against a locked door, and the ruling on each. Say the ruling, say the cost, and let them choose.

A second set of tools. One roll, by a second pair of proficient hands, and no third. Unless the lock is the thing the first roll cost, in which case the keyway is full of steel and no pick goes in.

The crowbar. Strength (Athletics), DC 15, with advantage, because leverage is what a crowbar is for. The frame splinters when it goes, and this door will never lock again. Heard through two closed doors. Against a barred door the crowbar has nothing to pull against: it is the axe or nothing.

The axe or the maul. No roll. A wooden door is AC 15 with 18 hit points; a heavy one has 27. Count the swings. The swings are a minute of noise that fills the building. An iron door is AC 19, takes bludgeoning only, and rings like a bell on every blow.

Knock. The door opens, lock or bar. The spell makes a knock that is heard three hundred feet away in every direction, and a second-level slot is spent on a door. Go straight to question five. Everything within three hundred feet already has.

Misty step. The caster must see the space they are going to. Through a keyhole or under the door they can see a square of floor, and that is enough. They arrive alone, on the far side of a locked door, with whatever is in there, and if the door is barred they can lift the bar. That is a play, and a good one. Let it stand.

Dimension door. No sight needed, five hundred feet, one willing friend along. Two of them are through and the rest are not, and a fourth-level slot is gone. Question five is waiting on the far side.

Passwall and stone shape. A caster who can shape stone is past being stopped by a door, and the door should not pretend otherwise. Passwall opens the wall beside it for an hour; stone shape makes a crawl-hole that stays. Through they go. The room beyond is unchanged by the method.

Mage hand. The hand appears in a space the caster can see. Through the gap under the door there is floor on the far side, and the hand lifts ten pounds. A bolt slides. A bar does not.

The familiar. A spider goes under the door and comes back with what it saw. An owl does not fit. Nothing a familiar can lift opens a door.

Fire. A wooden door burns, and with a flask of oil it is a hole you can step through in ten minutes. The smoke fills the party's corridor first. The glow shows under the door to whatever is beyond, the whole time it burns.

Going around. A room locked to keep people out has another way in, or it is a vault. A window, the roof, the coal hatch, the servants' stair, the privy chute. Name the other way, or say the word vault, which means one door, built that way on purpose.

Going back. Always allowed. The door stays locked, the scratches round the keyhole stay where the pick left them, and whoever holds the key will see them. Whatever is behind the door goes on doing what it was doing.

What the door is, and where the key is

For the door the map says is locked and says nothing else about. Roll once and you have the first question answered and the third.

D12	What it is, and where the key is
1	**A larder.** Locked against the household, not against the party. The key is on a string round the cook's neck, and the cook is asleep two rooms back.
2	**A strongroom.** One door, no window, the walls a foot thick. The key is on the owner's belt, wherever the owner is tonight. There is no going around.
3	**A sickroom.** Locked from the inside by someone who does not want to be seen like this. They are in there. They heard the pick.
4	**A cell.** Locked from the outside with the prisoner still in it. The gaoler has the key on a ring, and the prisoner has been listening to the pick with great interest.
5	**A back door to the alley.** Locked at dusk every night by habit. The key hangs on a nail beside the door, on the far side.
6	**A chapel.** Locked between services. The key is with the sexton, who lives across the yard and sleeps lightly.
7	**A workshop.** Locked by a craftsman who trusted nobody with the tools. The key went into the river with him a month ago. Nobody has been in since, and the forge is still laid.
8	**A nursery.** Locked at night so the child cannot wander. The key is on the nurse's wrist, and the nurse is in the chair just inside the door.
9	**A door with a wall behind it.** The lock is fine; the pick turned it. Behind the door is a course of newer brick, and someone went to a great deal of trouble.
10	**A kennel.** Locked at night. The key is on a hook in the stable. The dogs are awake now.
11	**A counting room.** Locked by a clerk who went home with the key at dusk and comes back at dawn with a lamp.
12	**The master's bedchamber.** Barred from inside. The master is asleep on the far side of the bar. The window is open, two floors up.

The card

The five questions

1. Is this door doing a job? If not, it opens. Say the lock was stiff.
2. What did the failed roll cost? A minute, a pick, the lock, or a sound. Say which.
3. Who else knows it is locked? Know where the key is. Barred means someone was inside.
4. What does forcing it buy and spend? Time, and the answer to question five.
5. What is on the other side right now? Decide what it did with the minute.

The numbers

Crowbar: Strength (Athletics) DC 15, advantage. Wooden door: AC 15, 18 hit points, 27 if heavy. Iron door: AC 19, bludgeoning only. Knock: heard at three hundred feet. Oil and fire: ten minutes. Mage hand: ten pounds, a bolt and not a bar.

♦

The adventures are mine. 30+ years of real tables.

LONG ISLAND DUNGEON MASTER

Compatible with fifth edition. Portions derived from the System Reference Document 5.1, © Wizards of the Coast LLC, licensed under Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International (CC-BY-4.0). The Door Is Locked and the Key Is Gone is original content © Long Island Dungeon Master, free to use at your table and in your own work under CC BY 4.0.